deciding chance, the ball trickling over the rope for six to lose the game. Feeling the cursed embarrassment and pain reserved for cricket alone, I do not tell anyone that my thumb is burning and burning then either, until Cathy Pickup, my teammate's mum, notices and, wine glass in hand, takes me to A&E, where they tell me it's badly broken**.** I do all these things in silence – I keep all these events in. I would rather sit there, in deep discomfort, than let anyone know any of it. Sometimes I think if I was shot, I would prefer to just bite my tongue.

I was hoping the Spar shop would be open and am relieved when it is – I have more than two pounds. I've saved the money from the Turkish Delight and cigarettes I usually buy outside the school newsagent every day amassing more of the loose change. I'm saving up long term for better football boots and batting gloves, but I'll have to dive into the savings today. I buy a ham sandwich and crisps at the till. The woman receives them, looks me in the eyes, for a moment scanning my face, before nodding. I gulp and nod back, taking from the look on her face that my eyes must be wider than I realised. She hands me my change. I wonder whether she too understands, like my mum, that I am doing something I need to do, and duly turns a blind eye. In her silence, I register her compliance and keep walking, against the tide, up the hill, out of Burnley.

I follow the signs for Heptonstall. I've never been to Heptonstall. I don't even know what Heptonstall is. All I know is that it takes me out; the signs leading there, and the steady inclination of the hill are my only compass. That way out. I'm walking beyond the Baptist Church, a huge sign reading 'Jesus is the only way', pointing towards the church and then also up the hill. I don't even glance at it. I keep walking. In this moment, I am leaving behind everything in my world. Smackwater Jacks, where I will drink jugs of Illusion cocktails on Friday nights in two years, Panama Joe's down the road, the Mortimers' house**,** my sister's school on the other side of town, all my relatives' and family friends' homes all within five minutes' walking distance of each other. I am leaving behind Burnley Cricket Club too, and with it the football team, whose ground backs directly on to the cricket club.

In Burnley, the background always bleeds into focus eventually. Walking out of the town centre and lifting myself out of the urban valley, the houses start to become made of the same stone that the walls are made of. The countryside that sits above and outside it begins to show on the